

25 Tamar

A wronged widow who claimed her place in Judah's family and became an ancestor of David and of Jesus.

Tamar was the daughter-in-law of Judah, one of Jacob's twelve sons. Her story in Genesis 38 is short, and it is not easy reading. She was married to Judah's eldest son, Er, who died. By family custom his brother Onan should have given her a child to carry on Er's name, but Onan refused, and he died too. Judah then promised her his youngest son, Shelah, but quietly broke that promise and left her alone and childless. Tamar took a bold and risky step that brought the truth to light. Judah confessed that she was more in the right than he was. Tamar bore twin sons, and through one of them, Pharez, came King David. Matthew names her in the family line of Jesus.

At a glance

Name	Hebrew <i>Tamar</i> , meaning "date palm"
Family	Wife of Er, then of Onan, both sons of Judah; her own family is not named (Genesis 38:6–8)
Children	Twin sons, Pharez and Zarah, by Judah (Genesis 38:27–30)
Key places	Canaan; her father's house; the road to Timnath (Genesis 38:11–14)
Key people	Judah, Er, Onan, Shelah, Hirah the Adullamite
Main passages	Genesis 38:6–30
Later references	Ruth 4:12; 1 Chronicles 2:4
New Testament	Matthew 1:3, as "Thamar"

"She hath been more righteous than I; because that I gave her not to Shelah my son."

Genesis 38:26, KJV

The life of Tamar

Genesis gives no dates or ages for Tamar. The order below follows the text. Genesis places her story right after Joseph is sold into Egypt, though the events may cover many years.

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| In Canaan | ● | Married to Er
Judah chooses Tamar as a wife for his firstborn son, Er. Genesis says Er "was wicked in the sight of the LORD; and the LORD slew him," leaving Tamar a young widow. <i>Genesis 38:6-7</i> |
| After Er's death | ● | Onan refuses
Judah tells his second son, Onan, to marry Tamar and give his brother an heir. Onan knows the child would not count as his own, so he refuses. The LORD takes his life as well. <i>Genesis 38:8-10</i> |
| Sent home | ● | Told to wait
Judah sends Tamar back to her father's house to live as a widow until Shelah grows up. Privately, Judah is afraid Shelah will die like his brothers. <i>Genesis 38:11</i> |
| Shelah grown | ● | Meets Judah on the road
Shelah is grown but not given to her. Veiled, Tamar waits by the road to Timnath. Not knowing her, Judah takes her for a prostitute, leaves his signet, bracelets and staff as a pledge, and she conceives. <i>Genesis 38:12-18</i> |
| Three months later | ● | Accused and cleared
Tamar is found to be expecting. Judah orders her death. She sends him the pledge he had left with her. Judah recognizes his own belongings and admits he was wrong. <i>Genesis 38:24-26</i> |
| Months later | ● | Twin sons are born
At the birth the midwife ties a scarlet thread on the hand of one twin, Zarah, but his brother Pharez is born first. <i>Genesis 38:27-30</i> |

Key activities

Scripture does not praise Tamar's method, and readers have long debated it. Some see her mainly as a victim who acted in desperation. Others see a woman who risked her life for her family's future. Judah's words (Genesis 38:26) compare her with him; they do not approve everything she did.

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- 1 **Married into Judah's family.** She became the wife of Judah's firstborn son, Er. *Genesis 38:6*
 - 2 **Suffered loss twice.** She lost Er, and then Onan, who refused to give her a child for his brother. *Genesis 38:7-10*
 - 3 **Waited as a widow.** She obeyed Judah and returned to her father's house to wait for Shelah. *Genesis 38:11*
 - 4 **Took a bold step.** When the promise was broken, she disguised herself and asked Judah for a pledge: his signet, his bracelets and his staff. *Genesis 38:14-18*
 - 5 **Kept the proof.** She kept Judah's pledge. When his friend came to trade it back for the promised young goat, she could not be found. *Genesis 38:20-23*
 - 6 **Spoke the truth quietly.** Under sentence of death she sent the pledge to Judah: "Discern, I pray thee, whose are these." *Genesis 38:25*
 - 7 **Bore twin sons.** Pharez and Zarah were born, and Pharez became an ancestor of David. *Genesis 38:27-30; Ruth 4:18-22*
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Group notes

Across Scripture

Direct references come first. Thematic echoes are study connections, not places where the text names Tamar.

Old Testament

Genesis 38:6–30	The main account
Genesis 46:12	Pharez and Zarah go down to Egypt
Ruth 4:12	"Let thy house be like the house of Pharez"
1 Chronicles 2:4	Tamar bore Judah Pharez and Zerah
Echo: Ruth 3:9–13	Another widow asks a kinsman to act

New Testament

Matthew 1:3	First of four women named in Jesus' line, as "Thamar"
Echo: Luke 5:32	Jesus came to call sinners to repentance

For discussion

1. *Observe:* What promise did Judah make to Tamar, and how did he break it (Genesis 38:11, 14)?
2. *Understand:* Why do you think Judah was quick to condemn Tamar but slow to see his own wrong (Genesis 38:24–26)?
3. *Apply:* Tamar was left without help by those who should have cared for her. Who around you is easily forgotten, and how could you help them this month?
4. *Apply:* Judah changed when he faced the truth. Is there a truth about yourself you have been avoiding? What would it look like to admit it?